# Lesson 09: Grammar Refresher: Misplaced and Dangling Modifiers; Prepositions

*English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation*

*Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 7.2: Misplaced and Dangling Modifiers; 7.11: Preposition Use.*

## In this lesson

You will learn to place modifiers next to the words they describe, to repair dangling modifiers by naming who does the action, and to choose the right preposition: *in*, *at* and *on* for time and place, and the fixed prepositions after common verbs and adjectives. Misplaced words can make a sentence strange or even funny, and wrong prepositions distract the reader, so these points help your academic writing say exactly what you mean.

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify a modifier and the word it describes.
- Correct misplaced modifiers, including simple modifiers such as *only*, *almost* and *nearly*.
- Correct dangling modifiers by adding the missing subject.
- Use *in*, *at* and *on* correctly for time and place.
- Use the correct preposition after common verbs and adjectives (*apply for*, *interested in*).

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| modifier | a word, phrase or clause that describes or clarifies another word, phrase or clause | the patient **with stomach pains** |
| misplaced modifier | a modifier placed too far from the word it describes | The patient was referred to the physician with stomach pains. |
| dangling modifier | a modifier that describes something left out of the sentence | Riding in the sports car, the world whizzed by rapidly. |
| simple modifiers | short words like *only*, *almost*, *just*, *nearly*, *barely* that are often put in the wrong place | Padam found almost fifty cents under the sofa cushions. |
| unintentionally humorous | funny when the writer did not want it to be | It sounds as if her head was too large! |
| preposition | a word that connects a noun or pronoun to another word; it often shows place or time | above, below, behind; during, after, until |

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| prepositional verb | a verb + preposition with its own meaning; learn and use it as one unit | apply for, wait for |
| adjective + preposition | a fixed pair of an adjective and a preposition | interested in, worried about |
| vacate | to leave a place where you have been living | I will be vacating apartment 2A. |

## Rules and explanations

### Misplaced modifiers

Put a modifier as close as possible to the word it describes.

| Incorrect | Correct | The problem |
|---|---|---|
| She wore a bicycle helmet on her head that was too large. | She wore a bicycle helmet that was too large on her head. | It sounds as if her head was too large. |
| They bought a kitten for my brother they call Shadow. | They bought a kitten they call Shadow for my brother. | It seems that the brother is called Shadow. |
| The patient was referred to the physician with stomach pains. | The patient with stomach pains was referred to the physician. | It reads as if the physician has the pains. |

**Simple modifiers** (*only*, *almost*, *just*, *nearly*, *barely*) go directly before the word they limit.

- Confusing: Padam almost found fifty cents under the sofa cushions. (How do you almost find something?)
- Repaired: Padam found almost fifty cents under the sofa cushions.

### Dangling modifiers

A dangling modifier describes a person or thing that is not in the sentence, so there is nothing for it to modify. It is often an *-ing* phrase at the start of the sentence.

- Incorrect: Riding in the sports car, the world whizzed by rapidly. (Who is riding?)
- Correct: As Priya was riding in the sports car, the world whizzed by rapidly.

To repair one, tell the reader who does the action: turn the phrase into a clause with its own subject (as in the example), or keep the phrase and make the person the subject of the main clause. After an introductory phrase, the next noun should be the one that does the action.

### In, on and at

| | Time | Place |
|---|---|---|
| **in** | year (in 1942), month (in August), season (in the summer), time of day, but not night (in the afternoon) | country (in Zimbabwe), state (in California), city (in Chicago) |

| | Time | Place |
|---|---|---|
| **on** | day (on Monday), date (on May 23) | surface (on the table), street (on 124th Street), transportation (on the bus) |
| **at** | clock time (at five o'clock), night (at night) | address (at 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue), a specific location (at Rooney's Grill) |

- A street name alone takes *on*; a full address with a number takes *at*.
- The book's "on" for transportation is true for buses, trains and planes; with a car or a taxi, English uses *in* (in a car).

### Verb + preposition

The book's list: agree with, apologize for, apply for, believe in, care about, hear about, look after, talk about, speak to / with, wait for. These pairs cannot be separated: *I will apply for that job*. Learn them as units: write each one in a notebook with its meaning and an example, and use it when you speak.

### Adjective + preposition

The book's list: angry at / about, confused about, disappointed in / with, dressed in, happy for, interested in, jealous of, thankful for, tired of, worried about.

- Examples: I am interested in musical theater. I am worried about my father's health.
- For a skill, use *at*: She is really good at chess. Henry is excellent at drawing. Mariana is brilliant at playing the violin. (The book says these adjectives are "always" followed by *at*. That is true for skills, but *good* can take other prepositions with other meanings: good for your health, good with children.)

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic often uses one preposition, meaning "in", for many times and places, so learners write "in Monday" or "in five o'clock". English needs *on* for days and dates and *at* for clock times.

## Practice

The exercises have no numbers in the lesson material; here they are numbered in order.

**Exercise 1. Misplaced modifiers.** Rewrite each sentence to correct the misplaced modifier.

1. The young lady was walking the dog on the telephone.
2. I heard that there was a robbery on the evening news.
3. Uncle Sayed bought a running stroller for the baby that he called "Speed Racer."
4. Rolling down the mountain, the explorer stopped the boulder with his powerful foot.
5. We are looking for a babysitter for our precious six-year-old who doesn't drink or smoke and owns a car.
6. The teacher served cookies to the children wrapped in aluminum foil.
7. The mysterious woman walked toward the car holding an umbrella.

8. We returned the wine to the waiter that was sour.
9. Emmanuel spotted a stray puppy driving home from work.
10. I ate nothing but a cold bowl of noodles for dinner.

The book has no exercise for dangling modifiers; practise them with your tutor (see Speak with your tutor).

**Exercise 2. In, at and on.** Edit Milani Davis's letter to Mrs. Salazar in the lesson material (it begins "I am writing this letter to inform you"). Correct the errors with *in*, *at* and *on*.

**Exercise 3. Verb + preposition.** Choose the correct verb + preposition.

1. Adomako does not _____ (apologize for, believe in) aliens or ghosts.
2. It is impolite to _____ (hear about, talk about) people when they are not here.
3. Manuel said he was going to _____ (believe in, apply for) the internship.
4. Jonas would not _____ (talk about, apologize for) eating the last piece of cake.
5. I _____ (care about, agree with) the environment very much.

**Exercise 4. Adjective + preposition.** Choose the correct adjective + preposition. (The lesson material says "after the verb" by mistake.)

1. Meera was deeply _____ (interested in, thankful for) marine biology.
2. I was _____ (jealous of, disappointed in) the season finale of my favorite show.
3. Jordan won the race, and I am _____ (happy for, interested in) him.
4. The lawyer was _____ (thankful for, confused about) the details of the case.
5. Chloe was _____ (dressed in, tired of) a comfortable blue tunic.

## Speak with your tutor

- "Give me eight sentences with dangling modifiers, like 'Riding in the sports car, the world whizzed by rapidly.' I will correct each one in two ways: with a new clause, and with a new subject for the main clause."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 1. Tell me if any of my new sentences creates a new misplaced modifier."
- "Ask me ten quick questions about my life and plans (When is your next exam? Where were you born?). I will answer in full sentences with *in*, *on* or *at*. Correct my prepositions at the end."
- "Quiz me on the verb and adjective pairs from the book's tables: you say *apologize* or *jealous*, and I give the preposition and an example sentence."

## Read aloud

Read the corrected sentences; stress the modifier and the word it describes.

1. The patient with stomach pains was referred to the physician.
2. She wore a bicycle helmet that was too large on her head.

3. Padam found almost fifty cents under the sofa cushions.
4. As Priya was riding in the sports car, the world whizzed by rapidly.
5. I am thankful for my wonderful friends.
6. Will you look after my dog while I am on vacation?

## Writing task

**A happy memory** (the book's writing application). Write 200 to 250 words about a happy childhood memory. Or, for a psychology topic: describe a memory of learning something new, and explain why you think you still remember it (memory is a PSYC 110 topic).

Use at least ten verb + preposition or adjective + preposition pairs (for example *worried about*, *talk about*, *wait for*) and underline them. Also use *in*, *on* or *at* for time and place at least three times, and begin at least two sentences with an introductory phrase (for example *Walking to school, I …*).

Checklist:

- Each verb + preposition and adjective + preposition pair is in the book's tables or checked in a dictionary.
- *In* for years, months, seasons, cities and countries; *on* for days, dates and streets; *at* for clock times, night and addresses.
- After each introductory phrase, the next noun is the person or thing that does the action.
- *Only*, *almost*, *just*, *nearly* and *barely* come directly before the word they limit.
- Each describing phrase or clause is next to the noun it describes.
- I underlined at least ten pairs.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

## Answer key

The book gives no key; these answers follow the book's rules.

**Exercise 1** (other word orders are correct if the modifier is next to the word it describes)

1. The young lady on the telephone was walking the dog. Or: While talking on the telephone, the young lady was walking the dog.
2. I heard on the evening news that there was a robbery.
3. Uncle Sayed bought a running stroller that he called "Speed Racer" for the baby. (The same pattern as the book's kitten example.)
4. With his powerful foot, the explorer stopped the boulder that was rolling down the mountain. (The boulder was rolling, not the explorer.)
5. For our precious six-year-old, we are looking for a babysitter who doesn't drink or smoke and owns a car.
6. The teacher served the children cookies wrapped in aluminum foil. Or: The teacher served cookies wrapped in aluminum foil to the children.
7. Holding an umbrella, the mysterious woman walked toward the car. Or: The mysterious woman, holding an umbrella, walked toward the car.
8. We returned the wine that was sour to the waiter. Or: We returned the sour wine to the waiter.
9. Driving home from work, Emmanuel spotted a stray puppy. Or: While Emmanuel was driving home from work, he spotted a stray puppy.
10. I ate nothing but a bowl of cold noodles for dinner. (The noodles were cold, not the bowl.)

**Exercise 2** (seven changes, in bold) I will be vacating apartment 2A **at** 356 Maple Street **on** Wednesday, June 30, 2010. I will be cleaning the apartment **on** the Monday before I leave. I will return the keys to you **at** 5 p.m., sharp, **on** June 30. … please contact me **at** my office. I have enjoyed living **in** Austin, Texas, … (*at* 356 Maple Street: a full address; *at* my office: a specific location; *in* Austin: a city.)

**Exercise 3**

1. believe in
2. talk about
3. apply for
4. apologize for
5. care about

**Exercise 4**

1. interested in
2. disappointed in
3. happy for
4. confused about (*thankful for* is grammatical, but the meaning is less likely.)

5. dressed in

## My notes